CHARACTERS (AO1) (AO2)

Mr **Birling**

A prosperous factory owner – who is ***'a self- made man.'*** Birling is arrogant, insecure, selfish, only cares about appearances and his social status and his business as indicated in ***'It's my duty to keep labour costs down.'*** He welcomes Croft into his family as he represents a business link between his firm and that of Gerald Croft's father (a rival) – this will secure his financial stability. Has a direct and detached approach to his workers; he tells the Inspector that he wouldn't listen to Eva Smith's demand for a wage rise ***'I refused, of course'*** and is surprised why anyone should question why. Mr Birling strongly believes that ***'a man has to make his own way'***. He does not consider the harm he may cause to other people because of his attitude. He is a **'hard headed business man** ' He is a magistrate and former mayor who is looking forward to receiving a knighthood – to be even more socially superior. He is optimistic about the future. He refuses to accept any responsibility for Eva 's death. He becomes increasing annoyed by the Inspector's questioning and Eric's unsympathetic attitude. He uses his power and status to threaten the Inspector through his friendship with the Chief Constable. The most disturbing part of the play for Birling is the scene in which he learns that his own son is shown to be a thief, a drunkard and is responsible for fathering a child. When he learns of all this he exclaims ***'You damned fool - why didn't you come to me when you found yourself in this mess?'*** At the end of the play he grudgingly wishes things were better but even here he still thinks in terms of money ***'Look, Inspector - I'd give thousands'*** He continues to ignore the shameful things that his family has done. When it appears that the Inspector might be a hoaxer he is happy to believe that everything is as it was a few hours ago. He copies the Inspector and laughs when he remembers the faces of Eric and Sheila and accuses them of being ***'the famous younger generation who know it all'***. This is an example of pride coming before a fall, a moment later of course he is panicking as the phone rings again. Mr Birling represents Priestley's hatred of businessmen who are only interested in making money. He will never alter his ways and it is left to the younger generation to learn from their mistakes.

Key Quotes

'You ought to like this port, Gerald. As a matter of fact, Finchley told me it's the same port your father gets from him.'

'Now you have brought us together, and perhaps we may look forward to a time when Crofts and Birlings are no longer competing but are working together – for lower costs and higher prices. '

'I'm talking as a hard-headed, practical man of business. And I say there isn't a chance of war.'

'So as long as we behave ourselves don't get into the police court or start a scandal -eh?''

'Sheila's a lucky girl - and I think you're a pretty fortunate young man too, Gerald'

'Fiddlesticks! The Germans don't want war. Nobody wants war.'

'The titanic- she sails next week'-'Unsinkable, absolutely unsinkable'

'man has to mind his own business and look after himself.'

Themes

Social Class

Reputation

Hypocrisy

Exploitation

Capitalism

Explore how Priestley presents the character of Mr Birling in ‘ An Inspector Calls’